resurgence of the Taliban. In this context, he argued, it was imperative that India engages with all political factions and not just the government or the Panjsheri leadership.[85] Managing this tightrope, however, was getting increasingly complicated, if not worrisome, for New Delhi. Ahmad Wali Massoud, Karzai's bitter rival, notes India's shift as follows:

> During the Resistance [UF] they [India] were supporting, like Iran and like Russia, the Resistance against terrorism and Taliban ... but since 2001 when the new government came, they completely shifted towards the new government. Now, the support that the Resistance forces enjoyed before this government, after 2001 they [India] gave none of this support.[86]

Corroborating this sense of alienation with India were four different interviews with Afghan media personnel and political analysts (all sympathetic towards the UF and its various leaders) who claimed that former UF leaders felt 'abandoned' by India's thrust towards Karzai in particular and Pashtuns in general.[87] Their indication was mostly towards Mohaqiq and the Massoud brothers. Haji Mohammad Mohaqiq, head of the Hazara dominated Hizb-e-Wahdat was cautious of India's infamous reluctance of helping its friends but was not as bitter as Wali Massoud. India did put a lot of weight behind Karzai, said Mohaqiq, but then it 'supports whosoever is in power and not just the Pasthtuns'.[88] Abdullah says that the sense of alienation voiced by various UF leaders is incorrect and the 'scope of their thoughts should have been much more than just a narrow line'.[89] Nonetheless, he adds, 'as far as India is concerned, we didn't have any particular expectations on a personal or factional level. But at the same time it has been our advice to all the countries involved that only listening to the government will not do the job. That's the official line. Yes of course they have to deal with the government of Afghanistan and the relations have to be based on that, but at the same time there is goodwill among the people of Afghanistan and there is the voices of the people of Afghanistan also have to be heard'.[90]

The message was clear: India's Karzai-centric approach had its shortcomings. What Menon discarded as a bound-to-happen phenomenon in a factionalised polity (or as a mandatory political cost India pays in engaging with Afghanistan on a state-to-state basis), was taking a toll on India's political capital in the country. And Islamabad had begun capitalising on the trend. Pakistan lobbied